



PROPOSAL FOR PILOTING MODEL ELDER DAY CARE CENTERS AT PROVINCIAL LEVEL

THE PROPOSAL

Verité Research recommends that the government pilot model elder day care centres, with at least one in each of the nine provinces. This proposal will address two key challenges that Sri Lanka is facing: (i) an ageing population coupled with limited options for support for families caring for elders, especially those with chronic disabilities; and (ii) the disproportionately high burden of care that falls on women within a household, which acts as a barrier to their freedom and economic empowerment. It also represents a meaningful step towards delivering on the Government's manifesto pledge to establish elderly care centres at the divisional secretariat level.

SHORT ABSTRACT

Establishing high-quality, accessible elder day care options will relieve some of the caregiving burden borne by the household, especially women who shoulder a disproportionate share of unpaid care work. We recommend piloting at least one elder day care centre in each of the nine provinces. This approach would provide the government with evidence and insights to guide scaling up of such centres to the divisional secretariat level as promised in the manifesto.

TOPLINE VIEW

Objective of the Proposal		Implementing Agency:	
☒	Governance	Primary Beneficiaries:	Ministry of Finance
☒	Justice and Rights	Cost Estimate (if available):	Women, the elderly population
☒	Social Welfare	Policy Type:	NA
☒	Economic Growth		Expenditure
☐	Other:		

HOW IT ADVANCES THE OBJECTIVES

1. This proposal is a step towards advancing the rights of elders to dignity, health, and social inclusion. State-sponsored elder care centres would address existing gaps in the options for quality and accessibility care. Importantly, these centres could be designed to integrate primary health and nutritional support and opportunities for social connection. They can also provide a safety net for vulnerable elderly populations, reduce social isolation, and promote healthy aging and overall wellbeing.
2. This proposal also supports women's rights to economic participation and personal autonomy by reducing the disproportionate care responsibilities they bear. By providing accessible, affordable, and reliable elder day care, the government can ease the care burden

on women, providing with the option to enter or re-enter the workforce, thus increasing the potential for female labour force participation.

3. This approach strengthens governance as it provides a practical pathway to implement the NPP's manifesto commitment on elder care. It enables the government to test approaches in diverse contexts, generate reliable evidence, and refine policies before scaling nationally to the divisional secretariat level as promised in the manifesto.

CASE FOR THE PROPOSAL

Sri Lanka's population is ageing - in 2023, Sri Lanka had the highest proportion of adults over 60 in South Asia, and almost a quarter of Sri Lanka's population is expected to be over the age of 60 by 2040.ⁱ The old-age dependency ratio (the ratio of population aged 60 years or older to the population aged 15–59 years) is also expected to nearly double from 2020 to 2050.ⁱⁱ In fact, the UN projects that Sri Lanka's population will decline after 2053.ⁱⁱⁱ Despite these changes in population structure, care arrangements for the elderly have remained largely unchanged in the last few decades.

Unpaid care work, including elder care, extracts a heavy toll on caregivers, who are usually women. A recent quantitative study of caregivers highlighted the intensive nature of elder care – many caregivers reported not being able to get enough sleep and having little to no time for activities outside of care work.^{iv} The same study also showed that this burden of care is usually borne alone - 92% of respondents stated that they often or always take care of the care recipient by themselves. A key factor that exacerbates this issue is the lack of affordable, high quality external support for caregivers of elders. Consequently, the demands of care work and the lack of alternative care options often prohibit women from any economic engagements outside the household.

Sri Lanka's changing demographics has created a growing need for state support that preserves the dignity and wellbeing of elders. Recognising the growing urgency of this issue, the NPP manifesto states: "While some policymakers view the increasing elderly population as a challenge, the NPP believes that it is a national responsibility to understand and address this situation with special attention to the wellbeing of the elderly."

The manifesto also promises the establishment of elderly care centres at the divisional secretariat level. There are 331 divisional secretariates in the country. Therefore, establishing at least one eldercare day centre in each of the nine provinces is a tangible step toward realizing the NPP's manifesto promises on elder care and demonstrates accountability to the citizens who elected the government based on such promises. Crucially, by reducing the care responsibilities that currently prevent many women from engaging in paid work, the initiative will also boost female labour force participation and, in turn, support stronger and more inclusive economic growth.

This proposal recommends piloting model elder day care centres at the provincial level across each of the nine provinces. Analysis shows that care-related barriers differ across factors such as geography and urban/rural settings.^v Locating the pilots in varied contexts will allow the

government to test models in different demographic, economic, and social settings, generating robust evidence to guide national scale-up.

HOW DOES IT HELP THE COUNTRY

1. Supports the dignity and well-being of the elderly population

Sri Lanka must respond to the needs of its ageing population – including creating spaces where they can engage with one another socially and be cared for well. Elder day care centres can help reduce the isolation and cognitive decline that many elderly people face by providing them with community and activities that they can engage in. These centres could potentially also be centres for health checks that support the physical and mental health of the elderly.

2. Reduces the burden of care on women and encourages economic participation

Female participation in Sri Lanka's labour force remains very low, and has hovered between 30-35% for the last two decades. International studies confirm that high-frequency elder care is associated with significant drops in labour force participation and paid hours for women.^{vi} Analysis of Sri Lanka's 2017 Time Use Survey indicates that women, regardless of their labour market and employment status, consistently spent more time on unpaid domestic work and care work compared to men. In fact, women spend over 8 hours on unpaid domestic and caregiving work, which is 4.5 hours more per day than men. Overall, women account for over 85% of total time spent in unpaid work. Establishing day care centres for elders enable women to remain the primary caregivers for their elderly relatives, while also providing them with the option to engage in economic activity during the day. Elder day centres therefore represent not only a social policy but also an economic strategy, mobilizing a currently underutilized segment of the labour force.

HISTORY OF THE PROPOSAL

There has been significant collaboration between the government, local universities, think tanks, and international partners to study and address the unpaid care economy. Notably, the NPP's manifesto explicitly acknowledges the undervalued role of care work in the economy and includes pledges to relieve the disproportionate burden on household members, particularly women. A consortium of leading academics, think tanks and policy experts have also collaborated to conduct research that analyses the nature of care work, the gaps in available care options, and its broader impacts on the country. This proposal builds on the insights from this ongoing research and the priorities outlined in the NPP manifesto.

REFERENCES AND END NOTES

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- iii World Population Prospects 2022 dataset, UN Population Division. https://www.un.org/development/desa/pd/sites/www.un.org.development.desa.pd/files/wpp2022_summary_of_results.pdf
- iv Verité Research. *Understanding The Care Economy in Sri Lanka: A Quantitative Analysis Based on a Pilot Survey of Unpaid Care Work* (Dec 2024).
- v Munas, H. (2025). *Mapping Sri Lanka's Care Economy*, Verité Research.
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